can be carried out without damaging the monument, whether mitigation measures are available (e.g. whether there can be conducted archaeological excavations, but most of the monument still preserve) or whether the owner should refrain from carrying out the work to preserve the monument. The latter is rare, as it is usually possible to find a compromise on the extent of the works or survey, or to move the construction works away from archaeological layers and structures.

Description of site

In the village of Kurese, 26 sites are protected as separate monuments, and the buffer zone includes beside them also the Soontagana stronghold. Among the monuments, the Bronze and the Early Iron Ages (1750 BCE–550 CE) probably include small cup-marked stones, a few stone graves, circular ramparts, but a settlement layer in the village enclosure, a burial place with cremation burials, some of the stone graves, fields banks and clearance cairns, etc., belonging to the Late Iron Age (550–1225 CE).

Assessing significance – methods

The protection arrangement for the Kurese monument complex, i.e. the establishment of such a large common buffer zone, is a rather exceptional case in the practice of archaeological heritage protection in Estonia. In most cases, the environment in which the archaeological heritage elements were created has changed significantly, which is why archaeologists and heritage conservationists deal with the preservation of the landscape's temporal multi-layered character in a rather localised way. An example is the attempt to keep stone graves or cup-marked stones in the middle of historic farmland in urban sprawl areas accessible to the public. For this, they should be retained in recreational areas between new residential blocks. There is no current or foreseeable risk of intensive landscape change in Kurese associated with high population density, but this ancient cultural landscape could be threatened by over-management of forests or fields, as well as by the construction of mines, etc. Hobby treasure hunting (detecting) cannot be regulated without protection measures as well.

The Kurese ancient sites were placed as archaeological monuments under national protection in 2018, i.e. before the entry into force of the new HCA. However, the criteria of assessment had already been developed by the NHB and were used as a basis for the assessments of the Kurese monuments – their age, location, scientific value and uniqueness of information, prominence and distinctiveness, continuity of function, written sources and educational value, and preservation. The Order of the Minister of Culture for the listing of the sites states: 'The Kurese complex is an invaluable resource for the study of Bronze Age and Iron Age society, religion, economy and life. It is possible to study the relationships between burial places, fortresses, settlements and cult sites, and their position in the society and way of life of the past. The Kurese complex is of high scientific and cultural value."

An archaeological heritage element identified by archaeologists does not have to meet all the criteria listed above to qualify as a monument, as even a partially preserved monument provides scientific information about the history of mankind and man's relationship with the natural environment (see definition of monument). At Kurese it is possible for everyone to appreciate the multiple layers of time on a cultural landscape and for archaeologists and environmental scientists to study the various aspects of the extremely well-preserved agricultural landscape dating back to the Bronze Age (Fig.23).

Figure 23: View of the Kurese cultural landscape and archaeological sites from the northeast. Drone photo: Maili Roio (NHB)